

was coming.

‘Fortune favours the brave. Next year could be tough, but I see the opportunity for big money over the next two to three years. What if I were to fund half the cost of the BSE card and arrange for office space for a reasonable rent?’ Monk asked.

‘Sounds interesting, but I am not comfortable taking such a big favour,’ I said.

‘Fair enough. Treat my contribution as a soft loan. Repay me whenever you can . . . in one year, three years, five years . . . Is that good enough?’ he asked.

‘And what do I have to do in return?’ I asked.

Monk leaned back and smiled.

‘You are quick . . . and blunt as well. Exactly what I had heard. Yes, in return you can do a few trades for me occasionally. Brokerage and margin money won’t be a problem. But don’t expect to survive purely on the business I give you,’ Monk said.

Monk’s proposition was tempting. But I wondered how GB would take it if I told him I was planning to start out on my own.

As though reading my thoughts, Monk asked me: ‘Are you thinking what Govind will have to say?’

‘Well . . . hmm . . . yes.’

‘Don’t trouble yourself over it. Govind will be happy for you. You have been with him for a while now, right? He gave you a break and you have vindicated his faith in you. What more can he ask for? And you can’t be indebted to him forever. It is time to move on, Lala. Think over it,’ Monk said.

‘Do you know him well?’ I asked Monk.

‘Not personally, but I know people who know him well enough,’ Monk replied, throwing me a knowing smile. I had no doubt that the Monk too did business for the big boys of the market.

I did not have to deliberate much on Monk’s proposal. Two days later I called him to say I would take up his offer.

‘Happy to be doing business with you soon, Lala. Just one thing. At any point, if you decide to quit the business, I should have the right of first refusal to the card,’ he said. I thought that was perfectly reasonable.

The same day, I told GB about my decision. I was certain he would have got to know about it even before I told him.